

READYING A ROADMAP
Congress leaders at the 85th plenary session in Raipur

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Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh.

On the face of it, all this sounds like old Congress rhetoric in a new bottle. But the Congress insists it's driven by well-honed strategy. Throughout the plenary, most senior leaders talked about the economic stress and social discrimination faced by common citizens, particularly the socially and economically backward and the minorities. The idea is to project the BJP as a party that delivers benefits only to a select few—particularly the elite castes. Rahul repeated a statement he has made earlier—that the Congress is not a party of *pujaris* (priests). That may alienate the Brahmins, but the Congress seems reconciled to the fact that the privileged castes are unlikely to vote for it. If in the past it has been accused of playing soft Hindutva, this time it has not dithered: take the resolution that it would pass a legislation against hate crimes whose victims include all sections—Dalit, minority, women—that have reported cases of atrocities under BJP rule.

The Congress is evidently seeking to build a new vote base, comprising the OBCs, SCs, STs, women, aspiring youth and farmers. Bharat Jodo is the rallying cry, but as an alternative universal narrative, it entails breaking what the BJP seeks to consolidate as a larger Hindu vote bank. The party has realised that soft Hindutva does not work; it will only dilute the existing Congress vote base. If the BJP is said to be bringing Hindus under one umbrella by propagating the fear of minorities, the Congress feels economic distress can provide a parallel and equally strong unifying force for the 2024 vote—particularly among the socially and economically backward.

THE CONGRESS SAYS ITS FOCUS WILL BE ON LOCAL ISSUES, YET ITS CHIEF PLANK IS GOING TO BE THE MODI-ADANI RELATIONSHIP

Hence the party's promises of a caste census, an anti-discrimination law, institutional finance to enterprises begun by SCs, STs, minorities and women, an education allowance for children who complete 10 and 12 years of schooling, an allowance to women homemakers who work without remuneration, fee waiver for applications and examinations for government jobs, MSP for farm products and ensuring that farmers get at least 50 per cent of what the consumer pays.

Simultaneously, the party plans to focus on urban areas, where it has been performing poorly in the past several elections. In contrast, Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) supremo and Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal has built his political capital on the back of the urban poor. If the success of MNREGA enhanced the Congress mandate in 2009, particularly in the rural areas, an 'urban NREGA', the party feels, may do the same trick in the urban areas. There are other promises too—construction of housing stock for the urban poor through priority lending, focus on cluster